

World Cup football has followed the same trend: The 2022 edition had every match worth Rs. 6.94 crore. Four years later, that value has fallen to Rs. 1.56 crore per match — a 77.5 per cent drop.

“The lack of advertising opportunities in football is another issue. While commercial partners can have ad slots after every over or dismissal in cricket, or maybe every set in tennis, in football, it’s largely restricted to pre-match, half-time and full-time, with limited additional breaks,” another individual from an Indian broadcaster says.

Potphode adds further insight. “The advertising market remains highly value-conscious, with brands increasingly seeking measurable and consistent returns across both television and digital platforms.

“With a crowded sports calendar and the continued rise of on-demand consumption, rights holders and broadcasters may be taking a more calibrated approach, evaluating not just scale, but the quality and timing of audience engagement.”

Will there be a solution?

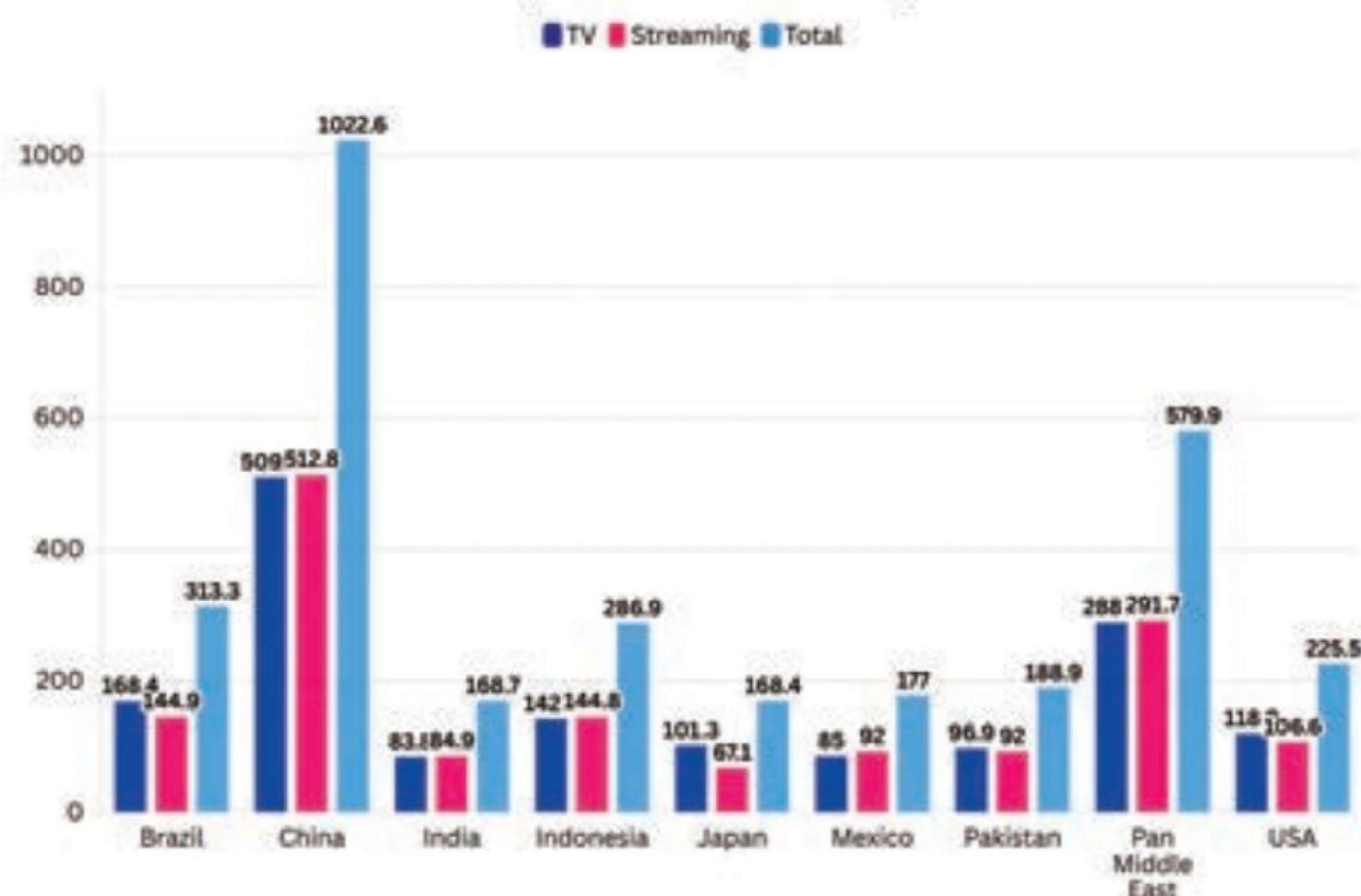
FIFA is expected to hold negotiations with leading Indian broadcasters — JioStar, FanCode, Sony Sports and ZEE Entertainment — in search of a last-ditch solution. It is unlikely for DAZN to enter the conversation, while Netflix and YouTube have chosen not to comment.

If all options fail, the World Cup could return to Doordarshan, India’s public broadcaster, after 28 years. Under the Sports Broadcasting Signals (Mandatory Sharing with Prasar Bharati) Act, sporting events of national importance must be shared with the broadcaster.

That could offer a lifeline, with marquee matches — likely the knockouts and the final — broadcast on Doordarshan irrespective of the primary rights holder.

Prasar Bharati, Doordarshan’s parent company, had made a profit of Rs. 3.5 crore from the 1998 rights. A return to public broadcasting could yet make the World Cup viable again in India.

FIFA World Cup 2022 viewership (in millions)



Numbers game: Of the 104 games in the World Cup this time, only 14 begin before midnight. In comparison, Qatar 2022 had 44 of its 64 matches before midnight, while Russia 2018 had 63. Nevertheless, India remains among the top ten consumers of the quadrennial tournament as evident from the Qatar edition.

